

Ministry of Water, Land and Resource Stewardship

UPDATE – Flood Watch – Bulkley River (UPGRADED)

High Streamflow Advisory – Central Coast (NEW), Northern Interior

Issued: 9:30 AM May 6, 2026

The River Forecast Centre is upgrading to a Flood Watch for:

- Bulkley River and tributaries around Smithers and Houston

The River Forecast Centre is issuing or maintaining a High Streamflow Advisory for areas including:

- Central Coast including the Atnarko River, Bella Coola River and surrounding tributaries (NEW)
- Lakes Region and tributary rivers around Burns Lake, Fraser Lake, Fort St. James and surrounding areas (MAINTAINED)
- Omineca including tributaries between Prince George and Mackenzie (MAINTAINED)

Weather Synopsis:

An extended period of high pressure is bringing seasonally hot temperatures across British Columbia. Daily maximum temperatures through the northern interior are expected to remain in the low-to-mid 20°C through Thursday. Overnight low temperatures are expected to remain above freezing. Snowmelt rates observed at Automated Snow Weather Stations in the region have been in the 15 to 30 mm range over the past few days and are expected to accelerate and remain elevated through mid-week.

River Conditions:

Rivers have been rising in response to hot temperatures and snowmelt. Several rivers at Water Survey of Canada real-time monitoring locations are currently flowing near or above a mean annual peak flow level (i.e. 2-year flow), including Buck Creek at the mouth (08EE013), Bulkley River near Houston (08EE003), and Pack River at the outlet of McLeod Lake (07EE010). On the Central Coast, the Atnarko River near the mouth (08FB006) reached 200 m³/s (between a 2-year and 5-year flow) earlier this morning.

Rises in rivers throughout the region are forecast to reach the 2-year to 5-year flow, or higher, through today and tomorrow. Low-lying flooding and bank erosion are possible at these levels. The Bulkley River near Smithers (08EE005) gauge is currently at a water level of nearly 5.0m

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(800 m³/s) and expected to continue to rise through today and tomorrow. Flows may exceed flood stage on the Bulkley River, and other headwater areas.

Fast-flowing rivers pose increased risk to safety. Stay away from rivers and river banks, which can be unstable. Never drive through floodwaters, as unseen hazards and current can be life-threatening.

The [River Forecast Centre](#) continues to monitor the conditions and will provide updates as conditions warrant.

For information on how to prepare for flood hazards, visit [PreparedBC](#).

BC River Forecast Centre

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A **High Streamflow Advisory** means that river levels are rising or expected to rise rapidly, but that no major flooding is expected. Fast-flowing bodies of water increase risk to life safety. Minor flooding in low-lying areas is possible.

A **Flood Watch** means that river levels are rising and will approach or may exceed bankfull. Flooding of areas adjacent to affected rivers may occur.

A **Flood Warning** means that river levels have exceeded bankfull or will exceed bankfull imminently, and that flooding of areas adjacent to the rivers affected will result.